

most—if not all—of the exercise you really need. And it's the best kind there is: low impact, outdoors, easy on the joints and the wallet.

Also, many specialty channels on TV and online cater to precisely the kind of exercise you want to do, from aerobics to yoga to Pilates. Not only are there more options than at a gym, but you can exercise when it's convenient for you. Plus you'll save on parking and gas.

These days, gyms are responding to pressure to be more flexible with their payment systems. Some will let you pay as you go, or pay for five-, ten-, or twenty-class packages. To avoid hidden costs or being charged for time you didn't agree to, pay for your membership in cash. That way, the gym doesn't have access to your credit card and won't be able to make automatic renewals.

Gyms cost a lot because they cover a lot of square footage and real estate is expensive. That's why boot camps in parks and informal running clubs are also becoming more popular. There are no monthly fees; it's a pay-as-you-sweat system that costs around \$15 to \$20 per class. The downside is that classes are usually available only in the summer. So Google around and see what's available in your area. If camaraderie is what you crave with gym memberships, then join a running club. You get the group support that makes it more likely you'll stick to your regimen, without all the costs. If you initiate your own club, then it's free, except for the cost of a good pair of shoes. And don't scrimp here.

I've focused on just a few big money pits into which people can unconsciously sink a lot of their hard-earned income. The problem is that these are rarely one-time purchases. They're continuing financial drains, the cost of which most people never consider when they make the commitment. So before you commit to continuing costs, be aware of what that money might be better put toward, and how much interest it would earn if deployed elsewhere. That's the essence of the truly savvy spender.